south and east Afghanistan.[70] Developing presence in all major urban centres of Afghanistan was given priority. Mukhopadhaya's predecessor in Kabul, Jayant Prasad, however, categorically states that he went to Kabul with a clear mandate of reconnecting with the Pashtuns in Afghanistan's countryside (a mandate strongly backed by NSA Narayanan).[71] The SDPs, and social contacts via the government and the various NGOs helped in achieving this aim.

India's conciliatory approach had two key adjuncts. Firstly, it was accompanied by a disconnect between the Indian embassy in Kabul and the MEA in New Delhi. Not only did New Delhi do little about this growing image of India's pro-Pashtun tilt and political indecisiveness in Afghanistan, but it also did not adequately understand the political strengths the developmental projects had imparted it politically. For Mukhopadhaya, 'sometimes in Delhi we don't realise that our biggest weakness [in Afghanistan] is not knowing our strengths', that is that India has not been very good at using its political capital for political outcomes.[72] Secondly, this disconnect exacerbated the growing disillusionment with India among Afghans from across the sociopolitical spectrum. Without a clear direction either from the PMO and the NSA (especially after 2010, according to some officers), Indian diplomats and intelligence officers working in and on Afghanistan were often left wondering how to execute policies on the ground.[73] In such an instance, when Afghanistan's security situation did get worse over the years, instead of holding to a firmly conciliatory approach, engagement with Karzai took a partisan turn. In fact, soon after the 2004 national elections in Afghanistan, India began to bet most of its political capital on Karzai, and dealing with different factions only via the palace.[74]

A partisan angle to India's support for Karzai developed as the latter settled into the presidency. In his first visit to New Delhi in January 2002, along with foreign minister and rival Abdullah, the first thing Karzai told Jaswant Singh was that Afghanistan's relations with India should be 'tactical' because of Pakistan. It was a clear signal of Karzai's limited enthusiasm for India, regardless of his university education in Shimla. Abdullah, who witnessed the exchange in disbelief (but also, to an extent, relief, for such statements increased his political value in New Delhi) claims that Jaswant Singh was 'shocked' by what he heard, but was too polite to make an issue of it.[75] Strongly holding the view that